

By Allan Ssempebwa Kyobe

URA upgrades to web-based customs service

Uganda Revenue Authority unveiled to the business community yet another upgrade in customs clearance processes. Asycuda World, a web-based Customs clearance system which will help lessen clearance time to only four (4) hours was rolled out this Monday. ASYCUDA is an acronym for Automated System for Customs Data. It is an upgrade and a more robust clearance system than the old Asycuda ++ which has been in use.



[CG launching ASYCUDA World at the Central Business Centre, Nakawa.](#)

While launching it at the Nakawa Customs Business Centre on September 02nd 2013, the Commissioner Customs Richard Kamajugo noted that the system gives clients the opportunity to make paperless declarations "We are running. The system gives clients the opportunity to electronically submit declarations. SMS are sent to clients on status of the entries thereby increasing transparency and efficiency." He said. Unlike the previous system that required clients to have an installed client software on their computers,

ASYCUDA World is internet based and can be accessed through any internet web browser such as Internet Explorer, Google Chrome, Safari, and Firefox. The system enables customs authorities and traders to handle customs procedures from their declarations, cargo manifests to transit documents electronically via the internet which results into quicker declaration processing. This implies that there will be no need for physical documents to the Central Business Centre as the case has been. Both traders and the agents shall be notified on the status of their import/export declarations as they are processed from the comforts of their offices anywhere in the world. This will result into cost savings both to URA and the trade community since it will eliminate the need to move physical documents from one office to another.

The project supported by Trademark East Africa (TMEA) was successfully piloted at Jinja customs station from November 2012 to March 2013 before embarking on a national rollout starting with Entebbe Airport in April, 2013, Malaba, Mutukula, Katuna and Mbale in June and July this year. Asycuda system has gone through several upgrades from 1996 when the Asycuda 2.7 was launched, Asycuda ++ to the latest ASYCUDA World.

Recalling the work environment in the past, Allen Kagina, the Commissioner General, said the upgrade is an important event in the transformation of URA. “I am pleased to be a part of history in the making. Even more important is that we are doing this together with the business community. To move, not URA forward, but this nation forward,” she remarked.

She told the audience that included traders and clearing agents that with the ever changing business trends, new processes and products are being rolled out to meet the demands of faster clearance times and security for goods. “Our focus now is on new challenges, measures to address them and make current services even better,” she added.

URA anticipates that with the business community reaping out of the ASYCUDA World with fast clearance, simplification of the clearance process

and reduction in the cost of clearing, there will be an expanded client and a profit base leading to improved income tax returns.

The Commissioner General also applauded TMEA for the existing partnership to strengthen trade in the region. “We are celebrating a partnership and I know that TMEA recognises this as a partnership and not a donor-beggar affair. At present, more than 150 customs staff in the region and more than 600 clearing agents operating in Kampala have attended the ASYCUDA World user training.

The Writer works for the Public and Corporate Affairs Division, Uganda Revenue Authority.